

Independent Church League 2026 Softball Rules

Philippians 2:14... "Do all things without grumbling or disputing that you may prove yourselves to be blameless and innocent, children of God above reproach in the midst of a crooked and perverse generation. Among whom you appear as lights in the world."

Let's try to make this the theme verse for our league.

1. All players are playing at their own risk. Each team will determine the eligibility of players. Women may play. Players must be sixteen years or older and provide a valid ID upon request. Most of the players should attend your church (this is also an outreach). Once a player has played for a team in the league, he/she is on that team's roster for the entire season (cannot play on any other team in this league until the following season).
2. Games will be scheduled for Monday nights. Teams must be ready to start at their scheduled game time. If you know you can't field a team ahead of time, please contact the opposing team manager. By mutual consent some games may be rescheduled. Schedule changes must be coordinated through the league commissioner. A team must field a minimum of eight players or forfeit that game. If you have less than 8 players, you will start as the away team. After a 5 minute grace period from the scheduled start time, if you still don't have 8 to start, it will be a 10-0 forfeit. A maximum of ten players may play in the field at one time. There are three methods of making out your lineup for each game.

Batting the Roster. Teams must bat all their players present for the game. If additional players come after the game starts, they go to the bottom of the order. On defense, for players in the lineup there is open substitution. This means all players in the lineup can switch fielding positions at anytime. On offense, the batting lineup cannot change except to eliminate batters. If a batter misses their turn in the lineup or has been removed from the lineup, they cannot re-enter the game period.

Baseball Rules Roster. Teams will play and bat 10 players only. On defense, for players in the lineup there is open substitution. This means all players in the lineup can switch fielding positions at any time. On offense, if you want to add another player, you must remove a player from your lineup and insert that new player into the vacated player's position in the batting order. Once a player has been removed from the lineup, he/she may not re-enter the game period.

Softball Rules Roster. When batting 10 players, the starter may be taken out of the game, and later reenter the game once, but re-enter only in the original spot in the batting order.

3. **Courtesy Runners** may be used regardless of what base the runner ends up on. The player must notify the opposing manager. The player that made the last out will be the runner. If that player is not available, go to the next last out and so on. Courtesy runners are subject to the roster rules as stated above.
4. **a. Time Limits** Managers are to agree on an official clock before they begin playing. For early games, the clock starts at 6:00 p.m. sharp (**no matter what**). No new inning will start after 6:55 (or 55 minutes for later games). Note: new innings start immediately after the home team has finished batting (as soon as the third out is recorded). In case of a tie, extra innings may be played, but still subject to no new inning starting after 6:55 (or 55 minutes for later games). Games may end in a tie. If the home team is ahead and time has expired the game ends at the expiration time (55 minutes). Later games should start immediately following each preceding game. The official clock for those games starts right after prayer (coaches should agree on the time before heading out to the field!!!). The last game of the night on each diamond can be played in its entirety (weather, daylight, and curfew permitting).

b. Last Inning is determined by the clock and does not have to be announced in advance. However, if the away team is hitting and reaches their seven run limit (see rule #25 below), and the game clock is **after 50 minutes**, it automatically becomes the last inning and the away team continues to hit.

c. Time Limits continued... City curfews require lights out by 10:15 pm in Neenah and 11:00 pm in Menasha.

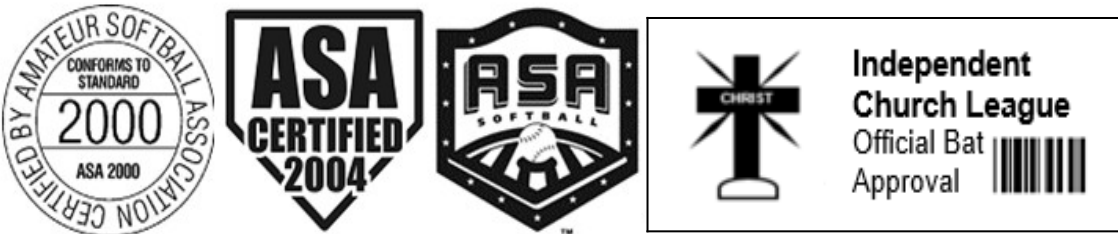
Managers Note: Hustling between innings can assure maximum playing time. Also, as a courtesy to other teams, when your game is complete move your players and equipment out of the dugout area so the next game may start promptly.

5. No metal cleats or spikes. Any player wearing them will be asked to change them or be suspended from the game.
6. The Independent Church League will follow the ASA (American Softball Association) approved list of bats and banned bat list. A bat must bear the ASA approved 2000, 2004, or 2013 certification mark and must not be listed on the ASA banned bat list unless it also bears an ASA approved re-certification mark. Bats must be official softball bats. Note: the ASA is now the USA.

Follow the link below to find the lists of banned bats:

<https://www.usasoftball.com/certified-equipment/>

The bat must bear **either** the **ASA approved 2000 certification mark**, the **ASA 2004 re-certification mark** (as shown below), or the **ASA 2013 Certification Mark (Slow Pitch ONLY)** (as shown below), must not be listed on an ASA Non-Approved Bat List with Certification Marks,



and must be included on a list of approved bat models published by USA Softball

OR

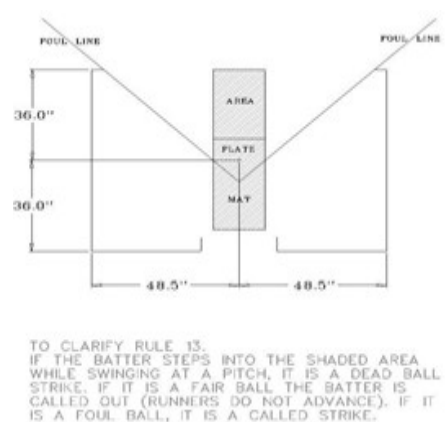
must, in the sole opinion and discretion of the umpire, have been manufactured prior to 2000 and if tested, would comply with the ASA bat performance standards then in effect. This includes Wooden Bats.

(Any person using an illegal bat will be called out, a second infraction within the same game will cause a forfeit.)

Bat disputes should be brought to the umpire/coaches attention immediately and they will determine the legality of the bat. If the umpire/coaches cannot make a determination, the bat will be removed from the game and play will continue without penalty. The bat dispute will be brought to the commissioner's attention and a determination will be made. This rule is for the safety of all players.

7. Game balls for the league will be restricted flight with a 300 compression and a .52 COR. You will use 1 new ball and 2 used balls each game. These balls are stored in the lock boxes. Both teams in the first game of the night on each diamond are responsible for setting up the bases. Both teams from the last game of the evening will put the bases and mats back in the lock box and replace the rubber base covers at the end of the night. They will also turn off the lights. Used game balls should be put in the lock boxes.

8. The diamond shall have 70 foot baselines and an approximate 50 foot pitching distance (farthest rubber from home plate). **Special rule:** a pitcher *may not* use the front rubber on any diamond, unless there is only one. However, the pitcher may choose to pitch from the middle rubber, if available. Once the game starts, a pitcher may switch from the middle to back rubber (or vice versa) only one time. After that, the pitcher must use the same rubber for the duration of the game. Pitchers who choose to pitch from the middle rubber assume the greater risk of getting hit with batted balls. In cases where the back rubber is less than 50 feet from home plate, the pitcher may take one step back from the rubber.
9. The strike zone shall be the width of home plate +3 inches and extend a minimum of 42 inches from the front to the back of the mat. The mat shall extend from 1.5 inches in front of home plate and then back for a total length of 42 inches. The mat shall be 1.5 inch wider than home plate on each side (20 inches wide total).
10. A legal pitch landing in contact with the strike zone will be a strike, two strikes (swinging, foul, or called) is an out. Three balls is a walk. No bunting, a full swing must be taken. No coaching of pitches is allowed by the offensive team. No heckling by a catcher while the ball is in flight, be sensitive to heckling the batters. If the opposing manager requests, the catcher must be silent.
11. A legal pitch shall be delivered with an underhand motion.
 - a. Must be delivered with a minimum arc that goes above each batter's head. If the pitch is not over the batter's head the umpire will call "FLAT" while the pitch is in the air. A pitch with less arc shall be called a ball if the batter has not swung. If the batter swings, all rules apply as if it were a legal pitch. There is no maximum arc.
 - b. The pitcher in taking his stance must start with at least one foot in contact with the rubber.
 - c. No side pitches will be allowed. That is, a pitchers' arm motion must be in line with an imaginary line drawn from second base to home plate.
 - d. The Umpire should call any illegal pitches (a, b or c above). The ball will be dead and the pitch called a ball unless the batter swings at it.
 - e. The minimum-maximum arc for female players is 6'-12'. A player may waive this privilege on any of her at bats. The election will be in effect for the remainder of the game.
12. Any non-batted ball is dead when the pitched ball hits the ground or is touched by the catcher.
13. The batter shall not step in the shaded area. Which is on the plate, mat, directly in front of the plate, cross over the plate, when he/she swings the bat. On a fair ball, the batter will be called out. On a strike or foul ball, it remains a strike.
14. A base runner may not lead off! The base runner cannot leave the base until the batter makes contact with the ball. On a contact play, if a runner leaves early they will be called out. No bases may be run unless necessitated by the batter becoming a base runner. If the batter swings and misses or hits a foul ball and the runner comes off the base...they are not out. Note: a contact play is a ball that is hit into fair territory.
15. A fair ball hitting a base runner (unless in contact with the base) before the ball has been touched by any defensive player or passed a defensive player other than the pitcher, the runner is out and the ball is dead.
16. If a base runner is legitimately off his base and the pitcher has the ball within an eight-foot radius of the pitching rubber, the base runner must immediately attempt to advance or return to his/her base. Failure



to do so will result in being called out.

17. A base runner shall not interfere with a fielder's play or the batter will be called out, ball declared dead and runners return to their starting base. (On a thrown ball, accidental contact between the runner and the fielder is permitted and play continues.) Example: the first baseman, attempting to retrieve an errant thrown ball, is bumped by the base runner going to first base.

18. Safety base rule. Note: First base is double size, half white, half safety color. The *batter/base runner* is a player who has completed their turn at bat but has yet to reach first base. The *base runner* is someone who has reached first base.

On the initial play at first base, either on a batted ball from the infield or outfield, a batter/base runner will be called out for use of the white (left) portion of the double safety bag. However, if the white and orange bags are both touched there is no penalty.

If a throw pulls the fielder into foul territory the batter/base runner may, without penalty, use the white portion of the double bag and the fielder may use the orange portion (right side). This is to prevent a collision or tripping of the batter/base runner caused by the fielder extending their leg across to the orange bag to contact the white bag. This exception is only permissible on the initial play at first base. If no play is made at first base, the batter/base runner may touch any portion of the double bag.

With a base runner on first and a ball is hit, the white (left) portion of the two bags must be used for tagging up and returning. The fielder may use either portion of the bag.

19. Fielders must not block any base without possession of the ball. They should stand to the side or front of the base, not directly in the runners' path until they catch the ball. Once they have the ball, they may block the base and apply the tag.

Scenario#1 If the defender is blocking the base with the ball. The runner must slide. If the runner fails to slide, they are out.

Scenario#2 If the fielder is not blocking the base with the ball, the runner may try to step around the defender. But, if contact other than the tag is made, the runner will be out. It is the runner's responsibility to avoid contact.

When a base runner knows he/she is going to be out by a considerable distance, it is the runner's responsibility to slide or veer out of the line of play, to prevent injury or interference. If he/she does not, and contact is made, the ball is dead, and the base runner is out. If the runner fails to slide or veer out of the way, and the play is a double play situation, the succeeding runner shall be called out even if contact has not been made.

Plays at Home Plate – an extra base will be set up between 6' - 8' beyond home plate in line with the first base line as if it continued straight past home plate. Coaches should agree on the exact positioning at the start of the game (some diamonds may warrant a shorter distance). There will be a commit line 47' down the third base line (23' up the line from home plate). All runners going home must use the extra base. The defense uses home plate (not the mat). Runners who step on or across the commit line may not go back to third and the play at home becomes a force play. If the ball reaches home plate before the runner touches the extra base, they are out. Note: the defense may use the 1.5" lip of the mat around the front and sides of home plate as an extension of home plate to "feel" the plate as they take throws home. Umpires must position themselves to see both home plate and the extra base at the same time in order to properly call force plays at home.

20. Infield fly rule (umpire to make the call): when there is less than two out and runners on first and second, or, first, second, and third. Any pop fly that an infielder can handle with ease is automatically out. The

ball can leave the infield, but must be an easy play.

21. On an overthrow, if the ball stays in play, the runner can take as many bases as he/she can get. If out of play, one base is given. (In play is within the fence or the imaginary line of the fence on first and third base sides of the diamond.)
22. There will be allowed three warm up pitches between innings to keep the games moving faster.
23. Both teams must email/text the scores in by Tuesday night before 10:00 p.m.
24. All league fees are to be paid by the first scheduled game. Teams that have not paid by the third game could forfeit games until the fee is paid.
25. The maximum runs a team may score per inning is seven, except the last inning. The last inning is unlimited. The actual scores for each game should be reported by each team. However, when the scores are recorded in the standings, the run differential will be capped at 15, if applicable. The number of runs scored by the winning team will be adjusted down for a max run differential of 15.
26. The batting team will provide an umpire to call balls, strikes, fair, foul, and plays at the plate. They will also supply an umpire in the field to call all the plays on the bases. This should not be the base coaches. The field and home plate umpires should consult together whenever there is a question on a call.
27. If any player threatens or inflicts intentional harm to any player they will be asked to leave the game. If it happens a second time, the player will be suspended for the remainder of the season.
28. If a player is not willing to abide by the league rules they will be asked to leave the league.
29. Max of 4 over-the-fence home runs per team per game. The 5th ball hit over the fence is a single, and any subsequent ball hit over the fence is an out. The batting team should promptly retrieve all balls hit over the fence/out of play, both fair and foul.
30. **Inclement Weather** – if games are not called by the city or league, the coaches of each game should discuss whether to play or not. If there is disagreement, and the actual conditions present potential safety concerns, the game should be postponed. Notify the league commissioner.
31. **Miscellaneous:**
 - ✓ In designated wooden bat games, all players must use wooden bats. The league will supply the bats (players may choose to use their own ASA certified wooden bats). Exception: female players may opt out of wooden bats.
 - ✓ No non-roster players are allowed in the playoffs

The managers will work together to handle any serious infractions of the rules.

Special Tournament Rules

1. **ALL LEAGUE RULES APPLY EXCEPT AS MODIFIED BELOW.**
2. **THE SEVEN RUN RULE IS NOT IN EFFECT.**
3. **(2) NON-ROSTER PLAYERS PER GAME ARE ALLOWED, ALL OTHER PLAYERS MUST HAVE PLAYED IN AT LEAST (3) GAMES THIS SEASON (ON YOUR TEAM, IN THIS LEAGUE). A NON-ROSTER PLAYER CANNOT BE A PITCHER.**

NOTE #1: IF A PLAYER DOES NOT QUALIFY AS A ROSTER PLAYER FOR ONE TEAM (PLAYED LESS THAN (3) GAMES DURING THE SEASON), THE PLAYER BECOMES AN ELIGIBLE NON-ROSTER PLAYER FOR ANY ONE TEAM DURING THE TOURNAMENT.

NOTE #2: IF A TEAM IS UNABLE TO PARTICIPATE IN THE TOURNAMENT, THEIR ROSTER PLAYERS ARE ALLOWED TO BE NON-ROSTER PLAYERS FOR TEAMS PLAYING IN THE TOURNAMENT

4. **ALL GAMES WILL USE, (1) NEW BALL, AND (2) USED BALLS IN GOOD CONDITION AND WILL BE UMPIRED THE SAME AS OUR LEAGUE GAMES.**
5. **FLIP A COIN AT THE BEGINNING OF EACH GAME TO DETERMINE THE HOME TEAM.**
6. **SEEDING FOR THE AFTERNOON WILL BE AS FOLLOWS. . .**

A. WIN / LOSS RECORD	B. RUN DIFFERENTIAL
C. HEAD TO HEAD	D. COIN TOSS
7. **A FORFEIT WILL COUNT AS A 10-0 LOSS**
8. **GAMES IN THE MORNING CAN END IN A TIE.**

UMPIRE POSITIONING

F1. With bases empty or Runner on 3rd only: The Field Umpire should be positioned behind 1st base, in foul territory, ready to take the angle based on the direction the play originates.

F2. Runner on 1st only: The Field Umpire should be positioned behind and between the First and Second Basemen at the edge of the grass, ready to go in either direction based upon what the runners do.

F3. Runners on 1st and 2nd, runner on 2nd only, runners on 2nd and 3rd only, and bases loaded: The Field Umpire should be positioned to the left of 2nd base at the edge of the grass so you can see all base runners and is ready to react in either direction. When in this position, plays at 3rd are shared with the Home Plate umpire. The call is made by whoever is in the best position to make it.

H1. Home plate Umpire position for Right handed Batters. For calling balls, strikes, fair, foul and plays at the plate.

H2. Home plate Umpire position for Left handed Batters. For calling balls, strikes, fair, foul and plays at the plate.

H3. Home plate Umpire hustles to this position for close plays at 3rd base. Plays at 3rd are shared with the Field Umpire. The call is made by whoever is in the best position to make it.

Several other key factors that should be considered in all of these positioning guides are:

1. Are we following the runners so that we are as close as possible to be in position to make the proper call? 2. Are you close enough and/or taking the proper angle for better observation? 3. Are we standing around and not prepared to move or react? 4. Once the runner reaches 3rd base and there is no one else on base, the home plate umpire is responsible for the runner on 3rd base. The field umpire should be back in position behind 1st base. 5. A runner on 2nd base takes off for 3rd base. The field umpire should be following closely behind and towards the direction of the throw in order to be in proper position to make the call. 6. With a runner on 2nd base and a batted ball indicates the play will be at 1st base, the field umpire needs to be hustling towards 1st base in order to be in the best possible position. 7. Always make sure you are not in the way of any fielder.

